The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Qatar's energy minister predicted that other Gulf **oil-and-gas** exporters would soon be forced to follow his own country's decision to declare *force majeure* on energy shipments. On Friday Brent crude hit $93 a barrel, its highest level since 2023. The next day, with markets closed, Saudi Arabia said it had intercepted ten drones heading towards its enormous Shaybah oilfield. Despite America's efforts to stabilise the market, many analysts expect the oil price to breach $100 next week.

The soaring oil price sent Wall Street **stock indices** tumbling. America's monthly job report, showing that the unemployment rate rose from 4.3% to 4.4% in February, made traders even gloomier. The S&P 500 closed down 1.3% and the tech-heavy NASDAQ fell by 1.6%.

Israel said it struck an underground bunker in **Tehran** used by Iranian officials, near to where Iran's former supreme leader was assassinated. It is unclear whether anyone was killed. Iran lobbed missiles back in Israel's direction. Israel also continued to bomb Lebanon, targeting Hizbullah, a militia backed by Iran. Israel Defence Forces say they have hit over 500 targets in Lebanon so far.

President Donald Trump said he would not negotiate with **Iran** and demanded its "unconditional surrender". Mr Trump said he should help choose Iran's new supreme leader, adding that the current front-runner, Mojtaba Khamenei, the son of the late Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, would be "unacceptable". He called a ground invasion of Iran a "waste of time". Earlier, the president slapped down a Fox News journalist who asked about reports that Russia was helping Iran pinpoint American targets.

BlackRock, the world's largest asset manager, capped withdrawals from its $26bn HPS Corporate Lending Fund as fears of a **private-credit** bust intensified on Wall Street. Shareholders requested redemptions worth roughly $1.2bn, or 9.3%, of the fund's value, but BlackRock limited payouts to around $620m, or 5%, the firm said. BlackRock's shares fell by more than 7% on Friday.

Iceland announced that its referendum on resuming discussions to join the **European Union** will be held on August 29th. Polls show the country is split; between 40-50% are in favour of EU membership. The country's initial negotiations with the EU began in 2009 but were shelved in 2015 over fears of the potential loss of control of Iceland's fishing industry.

Canada's prime minister, **Mark Carney**, called for **Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor** to be removed from Britain's royal line of succession for his "deplorable" actions. The former Prince Andrew has been implicated in files relating to Jeffrey Epstein, a dead sex offender, although he denies wrongdoing. King Charles removed his brother's title, but Mr Mountbatten-Windsor remains eighth in line to the throne. Britain's monarch is also Canada's head of state.

Word of the week: ***hujjat al-islam***, an Islamic title equivalent to a middle-ranking Christian priest. Read our obituary on Ali Khamenei.

Photograph: Imago

The threat of Iran’s Shahed drones

Israel and America appear to be winning the race to destroy Iran’s ballistic missiles and launchers before their Gulf allies’ missile interceptors run out. The Pentagon claims that the rate at which Iran has been firing missiles at its neighbours has already fallen by 86% since the war started. The United Arab Emirates says that whereas 137 Iranian missiles were fired at the country last Saturday, only three were on Wednesday.

Iran could be saving its best missiles for later. But for now, the biggest threat to America and its allies is Iran’s long-range Shahed “kamikaze” drones. These are cheap but accurate, and can be launched in waves from the back of trucks. Enough have been causing damage to pose a problem—one that there are as yet no good solutions to. The Pentagon is reportedly hoping to buy some of the low-cost interceptor drones that Ukraine has developed to counter the Shahed drones that Russia is fond of using.

Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump keeps one eye on the Americas

On Saturday Donald Trump will host the “Shield of the Americas” summit in Miami. The guest list is restricted to the president’s closest Latin American allies. Right-wing leaders from Argentina, Ecuador, El Salvador and Paraguay, among others, are invited. Left-wing presidents who have sparred with Mr Trump, such as Brazil’s Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, are not.

According to the White House Mr Trump’s guests have formed a “historic coalition” to fight “narco-terrorist gangs” and control migration. Daniel Noboa, Ecuador’s president, is deepening his co-operation with Mr Trump: on March 3rd the Pentagon launched joint operations with Ecuador against the country’s gangs. But other tensions could strain this coalition. The United States’ desire to diminish Chinese influence in Latin America worries countries that rely on China to buy their commodities and finance infrastructure projects. Working with Mr Trump on crime and migration is the easy part for Latin America’s MAGA men. Taking orders about China will be harder.

Photograph: AP

How animation rules the box office

“Hoppers”, Pixar’s 30th feature film, arrives in cinemas this weekend. The zany brain-swap comedy features a teenage activist, a robotic beaver and a strong ecological message. It could help to make 2026 animation’s best ever year. This summer there will be more instalments in the lucrative “Despicable Me” and “Paw Patrol” franchises, not to mention “The Super Mario Galaxy Movie”.

Such films are a huge draw. In 2024 “Inside Out 2” became the highest-grossing animated film of all time, taking $1.7bn at the global box office. In early 2025 it was eclipsed by “Ne Zha 2”, a Chinese animated fantasy which has now earned more than $2bn. (Only six other films have ever surpassed that benchmark.) It may soon be beaten by “Zootopia 2”, released in November, which has already made $1.9bn. Being part of a franchise certainly helps at the box office. Even if “Hoppers” doesn’t set the world alight, Pixar will have high hopes for this summer’s “Toy Story 5”.

Photograph: Getty Images

Harry Styles’s new direction

Harry Styles, a former member of the group One Direction who has become a blockbuster solo artist, releases “Kiss All the Time. Disco, Occasionally” this weekend. The highly anticipated album is his first since “Harry’s House” in 2022. To mark the occasion Mr Styles will perform the record in full in Manchester, near to where he grew up; the concert will also be streamed live on Netflix.

Early reviews have described the record as musically funky and experimental, but with lyrics that are a bit too meandering. (Mr Styles conceives of the album as “a long diary entry”.) His millions of fans, however, will not care. This record, like his others, is destined to dance straight to the top of the charts. Many have already bought tickets to his forthcoming tour, despite steep prices. His last concert run, in 2023, grossed $617m—one of the most lucrative tours ever. If you’re Mr Styles, things are looking groovy.

Photograph: Getty Images

Weekend profile: Mojtaba Khamenei, Iran's hidden imam

Iran's Shia faithful have long awaited the return of their hidden imam, who went into "occultation" in the ninth century. Now, some whisper, they may have one again. Rumours swirl that the Islamic Republic's 88-man Assembly of Experts has elected Mojtaba Khamenei to succeed his father, Ali Khamenei, as supreme leader. He will probably remain hiding deep underground. His father, mother, wife, sister and some other relatives were reportedly killed in Israel's opening strike of the war on February 28th. Some suspect he may have been injured too, or even killed. But his cult may survive. His followers still mourn the first Shia martyrs from 1,400 years ago as if they were part of the present.

Mojtaba, aged 56, has always been a recluse. Though he ran the *beyt*—the 4,000-man court that oversaw his father's hold on the state —almost no footage of him exists. Iranians who have met him describe him as modest and shy. He would drive to his seminary in a battered Paykan, for years the only car made in Iran, though he has been linked to investments worth millions of dollars overseas. In one photograph he peers at his father from behind a curtain.

His closest political ally is Hossein Taeb, a cleric who once ran the feared intelligence arm of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, the regime's praetorian guard. Together they hounded reformists,

backed—and it is said rigged—the election of a hardline president in 2009 and helped oversee Iran's transformation from a hybrid theocracy-cum-democracy into a security state dominated by the IRGC that crushed dissent.

For critics, Mojtaba's dynastic succession betrays the Islamic revolution that overthrew a hereditary monarchy. Even his Islam, they say, is wanting. He lacks the clerical and political qualifications that the constitution requires of a supreme leader. He has never held formal office. Nor has he published the scholarly treatise required of a *mujtahid*, a recognised religious authority—let alone attained the rank of grand ayatollah. And he lacks his father's refined oratory and intellectual air.

But for the men now running Iran, such shortcomings matter little. They are eager to project continuity. Of Khamenei's four sons, Mojtaba most resembles him. And as a veteran of the Iran-Iraq war, he shares the military mindset of the generals who dominate the regime. Before the war, some had speculated that he might become Iran's version of Muhammad bin Salman, the Saudi crown prince who sloughed off clerical control and eased verbal sparring with Israel. Israel's killing of his family extinguished such hopes. If he becomes supreme leader, paranoia and retribution will probably be his hallmarks. "He'll be an ultra-hardliner," a relative of his tells *The Economist*. Expect him to preserve his father's hostility towards Israel and America, resist internal reform and entrench the IRGC's grip on Iran's political system. And if he proves to be an absent imam? For Iran's ambitious generals, so much the better.

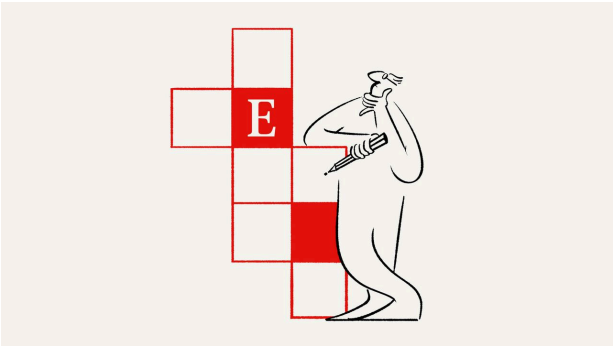

Illustration: The Economist

Weekly crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Author muzzles internal strife here (6)

2 across - Mix up tester strip (6)

3 across - Starting price of panicked retreat leads to growth (6)

1 down - Persistently attack methods to create flamboyantly betrousered singer (5,6)

Straight clues

1 across - Beleaguered strait in the Middle East (6)

2 across - Avenue or boulevard (6)

3 across - Burgeon; a largely unloved vegetable (6)

1 down - Fashionable former One Direction star who sings and acts (5,6)

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to . We will pick three winners at random and crown them in Tuesday's edition.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Skyler Hutto, Orangeburg, South Carolina, America

Hélène Tremblay, Gatineau, Canada

Vince Sinclair, Godalming, Britain

They all gave the correct answers of: Daily Express, The Signal and the Noise, conductors, platform shoes and a track. The theme is railways (railroads) which have express trains, signals, conductors, platforms and tracks.

The questions were:

Monday: Which British newspaper, when owned by Lord Beaverbrook, had the largest circulation in the world in the 1940s?

Tuesday: Which book by Nate Silver, published in 2012, is about the art of interpreting statistics?

Wednesday: Arturo Toscanini, Leopold Stokowski and Claudio Abbado all achieved fame in what role?

Thursday: What type of footwear, which raised the user's height, was very popular in the 1970s?

Friday: What musical term refers to both an individual song on an album and an isolated channel from a single instrument that is mixed with others to make a recording?

The great nations have always acted like gangsters, and the small nations like prostitutes.

Stanley Kubrick